



Ho Chi Minh in Paris

The Vietnamese leader visits the French capital in summer 1946 for talks on his country's independence. The French agreed on a path to limited self-government, but this was not enough to satisfy nationalist aspirations.

Declaring independence

On September 2, 1945, Ho Chi Minh declared the independent Democratic Republic of Vietnam in Hanoi's Ba Dinh Square. Emperor Bao Dai, Vietnam's traditional ruler, bowed to the evident will of the people and abdicated, giving his blessing to the new government. Although almost unknown in Vietnam until then, Ho was accepted as the country's legitimate ruler by virtually all social groups, including the Catholic Church. His government immediately began organizing an administration and set about tackling starvation, which was rife in the countryside.